

AI WORK / INNOVATION

Problem discovery and definition

IDEATION-2026-09-06-AI-WORK-01

IDEATION v0.2 | 6 September 2026

Evidence-led exploration of the Personal AI Work Coach / AI Workflow Transformation opportunity.

Research complete. Commercial evidence gates remain conditional.

Step 1 - Problem discovery and definition

Run: IDEATION-2026-09-06-AI-WORK-01. Version: 1.0. Method: IDEATION v0.2. Owner: Nadav / Codex. Date: 2026-09-06. Status: final desk-research artifact. Boundary: professional AI workflow improvement; no deployment or customer testing. Inputs: source handoff, source register and prior steps in this run.

Boundary and key output

Research how a professional can improve recurring work as AI capabilities change. Compare individuals, small teams, and service providers. Near-term boundary: one reversible professional-services workflow using approved tools; future software is an option, not a committed build. Exclude customer recruitment, live implementation, legal advice, deployment, public claims, and price publication from this run.

High-level problem: professionals cannot reliably determine whether changing a recurring work process will improve accepted output enough to justify disruption, leaving potentially useful improvements unrealized or introducing avoidable rework.

Journey and pain signals

Current journey: task arrives; worker assembles context; performs work; reviews; sends or files; repeats. A proposed change adds selection, setup, permissions, evaluation and ownership handoff. These extra costs must be counted.

PS01: user handoff reports unused AI potential (EV01, E0 as population claim). PS02: configuration waited on account access and a scheduled session (EV03, E1). PS03: no baseline was captured in the local pilot (EV03, direct record). PS04: no recorded commercial validation (EV04). PS05: observed productivity can differ from perceived productivity and measurement can be biased (EV06, context-limited).

Distinct problems

P01: a practice owner struggles to select a worthwhile change when many recurring tasks compete for attention, risking time spent on low-value improvements (PS01; hypothesis).

P02: a workflow owner struggles to put an agreed new process into regular operation when implementation spans personal accounts and work routines, leaving proposed improvements unused (PS02).

P03: a buyer struggles to determine whether a changed process improved accepted output when comparing executions, making renewal and adoption decisions unreliable (PS03/PS05).

P04: a supervisor struggles to recover an acceptable result when delegated work fails or its inputs change, creating rework and unclear responsibility (EV01; hypothesis).

P05: a practice owner struggles to decide when to revisit an established process as conditions change, risking unnecessary switching or missed improvements (EV01; hypothesis).

Framing challenge

The original learning gap is a proposed explanation, not an observed problem. We removed 'needs an AI coach' and 'needs agents' from every problem. P04 concerns failure handling; P05 concerns change timing, so they remain distinct. No opportunity ranking or cause is established here.

Gate

PASS for researchable, consequence-aware problem definitions. No demand-validation claim. Advance P01-P05 to scoring. Unresolved: frequency, economic magnitude, buyer ownership and prevalence. Objects: PS01-PS05 and P01-P05; inputs EV01-EV06. No numerical scoring in this step. Deferred: solution selection.

Source and evidence register

All sources accessed 2026-09-06. Grades apply only to the stated claim, never automatically to this business. E0 = hypothesis; E1 = anecdote/proxy; E2 = working support; E3 = direct primary evidence; E4 = repeated convergent primary evidence. No E4 demand evidence exists.

- SRC01 / EV01: User's Innovation handoff, preserved as source-handoff.txt. E3 for the requested research boundary; E0 for its unverified market and demand assertions. Direction: mixed. Earlier Storm/Red Team full transcripts were not reviewed; their conclusions are represented by this handoff.
- SRC02 / EV02: Local docs/service/offer.md and delivery-workflow.md, dated 2026-08-30. E3 for documented offer design, unknown for willingness to pay. Direction: supports an existing service vehicle. Existing AI Value Sprint: 7-10 business days, one Quick Win implemented.
- SRC03 / EV03: Local docs/clients/2026-08-30-michal-engagement-retro.md. E1 for generalizable delivery learning; E3 for the record's stated limitations. A related-party pilot reached setup, but captured no baseline and does not establish arm's-length demand. Direction: mixed. We do not repeat its claim that it proves the method works as a validated outcome.
- SRC04 / EV04: Local docs/gtm/fit-call-log.md, read today: zero recorded fit calls, qualified workflows, proposal requests and paid engagements. E3 for the record, not proof that no unlogged conversations occurred. Direction: contradicts any claim of commercial validation. Existing review: 2026-09-11 or ten calls.
- SRC05 / EV05: NBER, Generative AI at Work, <https://www.nber.org/papers/w31161> . Primary research surfaced in search; page fetch returned 403. E2 in this run because only the abstract/search evidence was accessible. Direction: supports possible task-specific gains, not universal uplift or consultant demand. Avoid transferring study effect sizes to this offer.
- SRC06 / EV06: METR, 2026-02-24 study-design update, <https://metr.org/blog/2026-02-24-uplift-update/> . E3 for its reported measurement problems; external validity to professional services remains uncertain. Direction: mixed. Newer study selection and timing problems prevent a clean current uplift estimate; the early-2025 slowdown cannot establish current model performance.
- SRC07 / EV07: Anthropic, Building effective agents, <https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/building-effective-agents> . E3 for vendor architecture guidance, E1 for commercial inference. Direction: supports using simple designs and increasing complexity only when justified. Not independent validation of this product.
- SRC08 / EV08: Zapier support and partner documentation, <https://help.zapier.com/hc/en-us/articles/8496213764877-Get-help-and-support-with-Zapier> and <https://docs.zapier.com/integrations/quickstart/app-developer-services> . E3 for availability of implementation/maintenance partners. Direction: contradicts claims that workflow implementation is empty competitive space. No verified competitor prices or small-firm outcomes.
- SRC09 / EV09: Celonis Enterprise AI, <https://www.celonis.com/solutions/ai> . E3 for advertised process intelligence/digital-twin positioning; E0 for efficacy in our target segment. Direction: contradicts novelty of a broad work digital twin. Does not establish a direct small-firm substitute.
- SRC10 / EV10: Microsoft Work Trend Index, <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index> . E3 for vendor research agenda; E1 for this opportunity. Direction: supports organizational adaptation as a live topic. Vendor incentives and survey selection apply; not willingness-to-pay evidence.
- SRC11 / EV11: Local docs/service/value-proposition.md. E3 for recorded positioning and founder-background claims, not independent verification. Direction: supports provisional fit with risk-aware professional services; reachable buyers and delivery capacity remain unverified.

Shared assumptions, risks, and contradictions

ASM01: reachable buyers have a costly recurring workflow (E0). ASM02: they will pay for implementation plus proof (E0). ASM03: cases share reusable structure (E0). ASM04: safe representative samples can be obtained (E0). ASM05: customers will later pay for revalidation (E0).

RISK01: verification/setup overhead erases gains. RISK02: no paying buyer. RISK03: bespoke delivery consumes founder capacity. RISK04: sensitive context leaks even after names are removed. RISK05: bundled platform features absorb the software. RISK06: provider grades its own work too generously.

Contradictions: general productivity opportunity (EV05/EV10) coexists with local absence of measured outcomes (EV03/EV04); these concern different populations and require a measured local pilot. More capable agents (scenario, not forecast) can increase delegation while reducing the price of setup; survival of independent assurance remains ASM05. Privacy differentiation in local marketing (EV11) is not proof competitors lack it (EV08).